

The name's Doe, John Doe

My rise to fame, and other stories

I am no one. Sure, I have a job, a family, friends, maybe even some enemies, but in the grand scheme of things, I really am no one. I'm not famous, rich or poor, neither a genius nor an idiot. If you met me today, you'd be hard pressed to remember my name tomorrow, and would certainly forget all about me a week from now. I'm just another unimportant and very forgettable human who means nothing to you, or 99,999,999 per cent of the world for that matter. All of that's changed now, though. Suddenly, I've become one of the most important people to have ever existed, and I must say, all this fame is rather disconcerting, uncalled for, and bordering on the ridiculous.

I really don't have much of a clue as to what changed all of a sudden. One day I was just leading my rather ordinary existence, and the next, I have warrants for my arrest, court orders accusing me of causing billions of dollars of losses, politicians baying for my head, random people defending me in their own weird ways, and the media circus that follows everywhere is hardly something that needs explaining... I have no real clue why it happened.

The beginning

I figure, maybe if I share my life with you, you could help me figure out where I went wrong. I was born in a country called India. It has both remarkable achievements as well as a boatload of problems. End result? Things are strictly average. I consider myself lucky though. I was one of the people who was born in time to see the

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great Internet develop into what it is today. Generation I, a magazine I read had called it once. Every generation after me (Generation O) will have already had the internet, with great speeds, and services such as Google just always being there... Of course, I'm not special, again, because I have this in common with a billion other people, at the very least.

And that's about all that is of note about my life. Until pretty recently, that is.

Recently

Up until a few years ago, life was good. I was able to live the life of the average Indian. I studied hard, like every other rat running the race. I worked the same way. I still couldn't afford everything I needed – never through school, college or even my initial work life. Thankfully, in India, there were so many like me that I was able to pirate software to ensure that I was in touch with global standards, or download music and movies so that I could keep in touch with global culture. I couldn't afford to be left behind, could I? Did I know it was wrong to pirate? Sure. But I always figured two things. First, there was no way I could afford to buy software personally, but I knew when I got a job, my company would be using paid-for versions for me. "All I'm doing is getting a head start," I told myself. Second, I pirated to try things. Would you pay money to go for a concert or a movie if you'd never heard of the actors or band?

I could sleep at night, like a baby with a clear conscience, even after setting my torrents to download – a ritual developed because of my night-unlimited net connection plan.

Discovering freedom

Even more recently, however, the Internet changed again. Web 2.0 the gurus called

it, but to me it just seemed like the natural evolution of a technology – becoming more personal, more about people, and more popular. Blogging changed a lot, because everyone was able to have a voice. Today that's Facebook, or your social networking platform of choice, and it was for me too. Of course I didn't make any earth shattering posts anywhere, but I did voice my opinion quite a few times, and learnt a lot by reading opinions from a million other people in the years that followed. Primarily, I learnt that there are a heck of a lot of people out there who think just like me, act just like me, have the same morals, break the same rules, and are from all over the world. Also, John Doe is a much more common name than I first thought! Things were going great. Life

INTERMEDIARIES GUIDELINES

The Information Technology (Intermediaries Guidelines) Rules 2011 were added to the IT Act 2000. These rules allow the government to pull up any website that hosts "objectionable" content via the intermediaries (website, domain registrar, blog owner and so on). It gives anyone the right to send "content removal notice" to an intermediary, asking it to be removed within 36 hours. Terms describing such content – grossly harmful, harassing, blasphemous, defamatory, obscene – are those that are open to interpretation. So, Facebook can be hauled up for derogatory content or pages on its site. It's so ridiculous, that even if you own a blog and someone else posts a derogatory comment, you can be pulled up. In March this year, Rajya Sabha MP, P. Rajeev, had moved a motion calling for the annulment of the intermediaries rules sometime in April. This motion, as would be expected, was defeated by a voice vote.